

COMPUTER ETHICS, PHI: 2180–001

3 CREDITS Spring 2026, Tolentine 309

Monday and Wednesday, 3:20 pm to 4:35 pm

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Office Hours: Monday and Wednesday 2 pm to 3 pm; and by appointment

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Advances in digital computing have led to paradigmatic shifts in knowledge production, industry, and global politics. Today, computing infrastructures connect all aspects of society. Their effects demand ethical scrutiny, but the fast pace of innovation tends to confound this pursuit. The aim of PHI2180 is to orient students to the study of computer ethics, a well-established and continually evolving academic field. We draw richly from the discipline of philosophy, indicating where theoretical inquiry clarifies the moral complexities of today's leading applications. Our materials are not strictly limited to philosophy, however: we also read texts and engage with new media from such fields as critical data studies, information theory, and computer science.

"Computer Ethics" emphasizes the durability and reliability of philosophical reasoning as a guide for technological decision making. Our premise is that a substantial foundation in ethical theory outlasts cycles of tech development. By the end of the course, students will be prepared to evaluate the ethics of new innovations for years to come.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

At the end of this course, students are expected to:

1. Critically discuss core ethical issues regarding computing, information technology, data analytics, and artificial intelligence;
2. Engage meaningfully in philosophical practices of writing, conversation, and personal reflection regarding these ethical issues;
3. Develop courageously critical conversation skills through active listening and constructive feedback; and
4. Think critically and creatively about the world in which they live and who they are in that world, with specific regard to computer ethics.

REQUIRED TEXTS

Silk, Matthew S.W., and Ian J. MacDonald. *An Inquirer's Guide to Ethics in AI*. Peterborough, Canada: Broadview Press, 2024. ISBN-13: 978-1-55481-640-8.

Other readings posted on Blackboard.

COURSE ASSESSMENT

Grading Scale:	C+: 77–79%
A: 100–94%	C: 73–76%
A-: 93–90%	C-: 70–72%
B+: 87–89%	D+: 67–70%
B: 83–86%	D: 60–66%
B-: 80–82%	F: 0–59%

Please visit the following links for further information regarding assignment of grades and access of grades at Villanova:

On what grades mean:

<https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/grades.html>

The Office of the Registrar: <https://www1.villanova.edu/university/enrollment-management/registrar/resources.html>

Final grades will be calculated on the basis of the following criteria:

Think Pieces, 30% of overall grade: There are reading assignments for each week, as detailed below. With the exception of the first week, there is only one Think Piece (TP) per week. The TP is a full, single-spaced page critical reflection on all of the assigned readings. Each TP must be printed out and brought to class, as well as submitted on Blackboard. This reflection not only provides evidence that the student made an effort to do the reading assignment but also to think critically about the readings. This is further evidenced by the student's having to raise a question for critical discussion based on the readings. See Blackboard for further information on form and content of the TP.

Follow-up Questions, 15% of overall grade: With few exceptions, each week will have a single Follow-up Question (FQ) based on the readings for that week (initially discussed in that week's TP). Like the TP, the FQ must be printed out and brought to class, as well as submitted on Blackboard. Unlike the TP, all that is required is the stating of a new question, based on both the readings and the discussion in the previous class. See Blackboard for further information on form and content of the FQ.

End-of-class Reflections, 15% of overall grade: At the end of each class meeting for which a TP or FQ is assigned, students will take 5–10 minutes to write a lengthy End-of-class Reflection (ER) on the backside of the printed-out TP/FQ. This reflection ought to consider the student's own performance, their classmates, and their instructors, as well as ideas brought up that were problematic, interesting, etc. ERs also serve as the means for taking attendance. Failure to turn in an ER means a marked absence.

TPs, FQs, and ERs are designed to hold the student accountable for their own learning, encouraging their independence of thought, while also developing a weekly routine. Since most weeks have class discussions on Mondays and Wednesdays, leaving just two days between conversations, there is not always enough time to complete difficult readings. So, the time between when a TP is due and its FQ is due is time not spent reading new material but reflecting on what has already been read and discussed. The time between when an FQ is due (usually a Wednesday) and the next TP (usually a Monday) should be devoted to reading the material for that new TP. Our Friday meetings (with a few exceptions) have no assignments due. Class is mandatory, however, as we will be working on the group project.

Group Project, 20% of overall grade: The last several days of the semester are devoted to student groups presenting on specific cases regarding computer ethics. These presentations offer students the opportunity to become the professor and thus inform and provoke conversation with the rest of the class. Throughout the semester, there will be opportunities in class for students to work with their groups as they complete stages building up to the presentation itself.

Final Essay, 20% of overall grade: In the spirit of the TPs, the FQs, the ERs, the Group Projects, and the conversations, the final essay is a capstone for the course that serves as an opportunity for students to reflect upon what they have learned and why they have learned it. A prompt for this essay will be provided later in the semester.

COURSE POLICIES

Standards of Conduct

Preparation: I expect you to come to class ready to engage with ideas. The best way to do this is to have done the readings, taken notes, and talk with me and your classmates. See on Blackboard the PDF on How to Succeed in this Course for further details.

Participation: Philosophy is hard to read and hard to do; but the only way to get better at it is to give it your best. This means that, during opportunities in class meetings to discuss in either small groups or with the class as a whole, you are prepared to speak up *and* to listen carefully.

Respect: We currently live in a time of heated emotion and disagreement over nearly everything. Too often this leads people to react without thinking and to criticize or attack the person, not the position. We are all trying to learn about very difficult things, many of which will make you uncomfortable. Instead of letting emotions or biases get the better of you, let's try together to examine the reasons behind the positions people (both inside and outside of our classroom) might have for holding those views. Only through respectful examination, and courageous conversation can we improve our understanding of ourselves, of each other, and of the world.

Classroom Expectations

Organization: At the beginning of each class meeting, I will make any announcements and then ask if there are any questions about the course mechanics. We will then break into small groups of 4–5 students to share their TP questions and then decide what question to write on the board to share with the class as a whole. After the questions are shared, the class will begin discussion as a whole. See the PDF on Conversation Rules. My job will be to guide the conversation constructively.

Discussion: When we are in the midst of a class discussion, I will help whoever is speaking keep track of anyone who might raise their hand to respond. But it is the speaker's responsibility to choose who speaks next. Remember that this is a conversation with and for everybody. It is not a discussion with me, the instructor, and you. So, be sure to make eye contact with everyone, not me alone.

Feedback: My goal is to have your reflections graded and returned within one week of receiving them. Ideally, I'll have them back to you the next class; but, as you can all appreciate, life happens. If I anticipate a greater delay, I will let you know.

Email Policy: The best way to communicate with me outside of class is email. My office phone will be answered when I'm in the office, but that will be very rarely. Leaving a voicemail may mean I do not get the message for several days. So, your best option is to email me. Monday through Friday, I am usually fairly prompt in replying to student emails. If I do not reply to your email within a business day, please re-send it as I may never have received it. During breaks and weekends, I may not get to your email until the next business day. So please be patient.

Office Hours: I set aside a few hours outside of class specifically to talk with students. I encourage each of you to stop by to talk. What we talk about can range from specific problems you're having in class to big ideas you want to talk through with someone. While I am happy to help you solve class problems (whether it's something to do with course mechanics to improving your understanding of an idea), I am also quite happy to talk philosophy beyond what is assigned in this course. Please keep in mind that these office hours have the specific purpose of meeting with students, so you are never bothering nor disturbing me by stopping by. If you are unable to make my posted office

hours or you wish to guarantee time with me during my posted office hours, please use my Microsoft Bookings page to see my availability. I'm available to meet via Zoom during both my office hours and outside of them (my preference would be to meet via Zoom on Tuesdays and Thursdays). You may access my Bookings page here: <https://outlook.office.com/bookwithme/user/16e528cc75774ce797385edec05ee7da@villanova.edu?anonymous&ismsaljsauthenabed&ep=plink> This link is also available on Blackboard and in my email signature. If you have any difficulties using it, please email me, and we can schedule from there.

Attendance, Late Work, and Technology

You are expected to attend all class meetings, to turn in all work on time, and to use technology responsibly. You are also expected to be responsible by taking initiative should you require accommodation. For example, reaching out to me before missing a class, before turning in late work, etc.

Attendance Policy: In order to earn participation points, you must first attend class. Attendance is related to *attention*, so even if you are not actively speaking, I nevertheless expect you to be actively listening. I will take attendance every class meeting. If you are sick, please email me prior to class to earn your excused absence. Depending on circumstances, I may request that you provide a medical excuse issued by the appropriate healthcare provider. If there is an emergency that keeps you from coming to class, please take care of the emergency first. Once you're able to email me regarding the situation, please do so. You'll find that if I'm kept in the loop, I can be very accommodating. But if I'm left in the dark, there is little to nothing I can do. For non-illness and non-emergency reasons for missing class (e.g., religious holidays, athletics, other appropriate extra-curriculars), you must inform me via email about your absence beforehand. If you provide me good reason to excuse you, then I will. But it must be prior to the missed class.

Please note that habitual lateness or regularly leaving early will count as being absent. Please, also be aware that a first-year student will receive a grade of "Y" (failure) whenever the number of unexcused absences in a course exceeds twice the number of weekly class meetings for the course. This means that you will fail this class if you missed more than 6 classes. To learn more about the first-year attendance policy and what counts as excused absences, see <https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/attendance.html>.

Personal Days: In addition to the attendance policy stated above, students are entitled to two excused absences for any reason that may contribute to their personal wellness. Students must advise the instructor by email before class of their intent to utilize a Personal Day as the reason for their absence. A Personal Day will not be approved

retroactively. Students may, but are not required, to provide additional information regarding their absence. Additionally, Personal Days may not:

- be used on consecutive class days;
- be used in the same week;
- be used immediately preceding or following a University holiday or break period;
- be used on days when exams, presentations or other major assignments are scheduled.

A Personal Day does not grant an automatic extension for items due. Students remain responsible for all assignments, exams, presentations, etc. due on that date. It is in the instructor's discretion to determine whether any extension is appropriate given individual circumstances.

Absences for Religious Holidays: Villanova University makes every reasonable effort to allow members of the community to observe their religious holidays, consistent with the University's obligations, responsibilities, and policies. Students who expect to miss a class or assignment due to the observance of a religious holiday should discuss the matter with their professors as soon as possible, normally at least two weeks in advance. Absence from classes or examinations for religious reasons does not relieve students from responsibility for any part of the course work required during the absence.

<https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/religiousholidays.html>

Late Work Policy: Generally speaking, I expect your work turned in before the deadline. However, I do understand that life can get unexpectedly complicated. If you come to me beforehand, I am open to granting extensions in the joint effort to help you succeed. If you fail to contact me ahead of time (and the more time ahead, the better), the default assumption is that you earn a zero on the assignment. I am nevertheless open to hearing your case if you believe that an exception is warranted. Any partial credit will be given on a case-by-case basis.

Technology: Doing ethics is difficult and requires your full attention. Smartphones and laptops are banned from use in the classroom, including the time before class starts, unless otherwise instructed. When you walk into the room, smartphones and associated devices (e.g., earbuds or headphones) must already be put away. The time before class should be devoted to getting into the mindset for class. This means you pull out your notes, open up a paper notebook or an electronic tablet (if necessary), and review the relevant material. You may also consider talking to your peers or to your professor about anything. Experience and empirical research show that the presence of smartphones undermines attention and critical thinking. Since that's what is required of you during our class meetings, we must prepare by ridding ourselves of unnecessary devices.

If your use of a tablet has the effect of using a smartphone, then we will have a conversation about the distraction. If you are unable to change your behavior, your use of any digital technology during class time will be prohibited.

In the instance that you are expecting an emergency call, please inform me ahead of time. I may ask you to sit close to the door, so that you can leave the room with minimal disruption to take the call.

Academic Integrity: All students are expected to uphold Villanova's Academic Integrity Policy and Code. Any incident of academic dishonesty will be reported to the Dean of the College of Liberal Arts and Sciences for disciplinary action. You may view the University's Academic Integrity Policy and Code for a detailed description. If a student is found responsible for an academic integrity violation, which results in a grade penalty, they may not WX the course unless they are approved to WX for significant medical reasons. Students applying for a WX based on significant medical reasons, must submit documentation and their request for an exception will be considered.

The use of artificial intelligence, such as ChatGPT or the like, is strongly discouraged to use on your Think Pieces. Its inappropriate use will result in an academic integrity violation and a zero on the assignment or in the course as a whole.

These are unprecedented times with this new technology. It is not going anywhere, so we need to be honest about how we are using it. If you decide to use ChatGPT or the like in studying for this course, in composing the Think Pieces, etc., then you are responsible for any errors ChatGPT or the like may make (and they make many) as well as for documenting what you have generated with ChatGPT or the like as well as how. For more on this documentation, please review the Think Piece Overview posted on Blackboard.

Inappropriate use of ChatGPT and the like will result in an academic integrity violation and a zero on the assignment or in the course as a whole.

Remember the goals of this course. The following statements (with appropriate modification to this course) come from the Code of Academic Integrity (<https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/integrity/code.html>) and are worth keeping in mind:

“When completing an individual class assessment (i.e. a reading reflection or the final exam essay) students shall rely on their own mastery of the subject and not attempt to receive help in any way not explicitly approved by the instructor.” If you believe you have good reasons for using A.I.-generated material for an assignment, I encourage you to discuss it with me ahead of time.

“Plagiarism is defined as the appropriation of another’s work and the unacknowledged submission or incorporation of that work as one’s own offered for credit. This includes work generated by or originating from non-human sources such as A.I. Plagiarism takes place whether it is accidental or intentional.” This statement applies to A.I.-generated material even if edited.

“Students shall not falsify, invent, or use in a deliberately misleading way any information, data, or citations in any assignment.” Often A.I. will generate false citations or actual citations that do not correspond with the material.

If a student is caught plagiarizing or cheating, they may automatically fail the course and be processed through the university’s conduct system. The selling of class notes or other course materials to others — students or a third party for resale — is forbidden. Without proper citation, the reuse of your own previous work may count as plagiarism. I will run all student work through plagiarism-checking software in the effort to ensure academic integrity.

If you are unclear about whether your written work risks plagiarism, I would much rather you come to me with a draft and questions about it, prior to your official submission of the work. That way, we can address your concerns, ensuring you have learned what to do and what not to do. But once you have submitted work, it is too late to correct any errors.

Lastly, if questions arise about the authorship of student-submitted work, it is the student’s responsibility to authenticate authorship. Students should save evidence of their authorial process, such as drafts, notes, version histories, and transcripts of A.I. assistance (when appropriate).

Office for Access & Disability Services (ADS) and Learning Support Services (LSS): It is the policy of Villanova to make reasonable academic accommodations for qualified individuals with disabilities. All students who need accommodations should go to Clockwork for Students via myNOVA to complete the Online Intake or to send accommodation letters to professors. Go to the LSS website <http://learningsupportservices.villanova.edu> or the ADS website <https://www1.villanova.edu/university/student-life/ads.html> for registration guidelines and instructions. If you have any questions please contact LSS at 610-519-5176 or learning.support.services@villanova.edu, or ADS at 610-519-3209 or ods@villanova.edu.

Sexual Violence

If you experienced sexual violence, please know that I am here to support you by listening or connecting you to campus and community resources. Also know that *all* Villanova employees, with the exception of counselors/therapists and/or priests in their pastoral capacity, are mandatory reporters. If you choose to disclose the assault with me,

I must report the event to the Title IX coordinator. To learn more, see <https://www1.villanova.edu/university/sexual-misconduct/faculty-staff.html>.

TENTATIVE READING SCHEDULE: Students are expected and required to read the listed readings in the order they are listed for the day the Think Piece is due (in most cases, this is Monday). Follow-Up Questions are due the following class meeting (in most cases, this is Wednesday). The first two weeks only have Think Pieces due, each on that week's Wednesday.

Unit 1: An Introduction to Ethics, Computers, and Artificial Intelligence

Week 1

M, 1/12:

- Introduction to Course;

W, 1/14: TP1 due by 3 pm

- Solymosi, "Think Piece Overview";
- Dewey, "The Analysis of a Complete Act of Thought";
- "Tech guru Jaron Lanier: 'The danger isn't that AI destroys us. It's that it drives us insane'";
- Shaw & Hilton, "You're a Computer Science Major. Don't Panic"; &
- Appiah, "The Age of De-Skilling"

Week 2

M, 1/19:

- No Class, MLK Day

W, 1/21: TP2 due by 3 pm

- Dewey, "Three Independent Factors of Morality";
- Association for Computing Machinery Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct;
- Vatican, "Communiqué of the Dicastery for Promoting Integral Human Development: Theme of the Message for World Peace Day 2024, 08.08.2023"; &
- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 1, "Ethical Inquiry" in *An Inquirer's Guide to Ethics in AI*

Week 3

M, 1/26: TP3 due by 3 pm

- Bynum, "Norbert Wiener and the Rise of Information Ethics"; &
- Vallor, "Technomoral Wisdom for an Uncertain Future: 21st Century Virtues"

W, 1/28: FQ1 due by 3 pm

Unit 2: Moral Responsibility and Values in Science

Week 4

M, 2/2: TP4 due by 3 pm

- Leonelli, "What Counts as Data?";
- Winner, "Do Artifacts Have Politics?";
- Koopman, "Informational Persons and Our Informational Politics"; &

- Koopman, “Reconstructing Democratic Equality in Data Technology from Paper Records to Artificial Intelligence”

W, 9/17: FQ2 due by 3 pm

Week 5

M, 2/9: TP5 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 2, “The Moral Responsibility of Scientists” in *An Inquirer’s Guide to Ethics in AI*;
- Douglas, “The Importance of Values for Science”;
- Friedman, “Value Sensitive Design”;
- Friedman, “Value-sensitive Design” (two separate but short readings by the same author); &
- Johnson, “Are Algorithms Value-Free? Feminist Theoretical Virtues in Machine Learning”

W, 2/11: FQ3 due by 3 pm;

Unit 3: Bias and Machine Learning in Data Science and Politics

Week 6

M, 2/16: TP6 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 3, “Bias and Machine Learning” in *An Inquirer’s Guide to Ethics in AI*, pp. 75–102 (till end of §2); &
- Martin, “Algorithmic Bias and Corporate Responsibility: How Companies Hide behind the False Veil of the Technological Imperative”

W, 2/18: FQ4 due by 3 pm

Week 7

M, 2/23: TP7 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 3, “Bias and Machine Learning” in *An Inquirer’s Guide to Ethics in AI*, pp. 102–118;
- Martin and Villegas-Gallaviz, “AI and Corporate Responsibility”;
- Martin, “Finding Consumers, No Matter Where They Hide: Ad Targeting and Location Data”;
- Hill, “How a Company You’ve Never Heard of Sends You Letters about Your Medical Condition”;
- Hill, “Wrongfully Accused by an Algorithm”;
- Lohr, “Facial Recognition is Accurate, if You’re a White Guy”;
- Hill, “Can You Hide a Child’s Face from AI?”; &
- Harwell, “This Facial Recognition Website Can Turn Anyone into a Cop — or a Stalker”

W, 2/25: FQ5 due by 3 pm

Spring Break (3/2 and 3/4): No Classes

Week 8

M, 3/9: TP8 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 4, “Opacity, Risk, and Error” in *An Inquirer’s Guide to Ethics in AI*;

- Bedi & McGrory, "Pasco's Sheriff Uses Grades and Abuse Histories to Label Schoolchildren Potential Criminals: The Kids and Their Parents Don't Know";
- Harwell, "Cheating-Detection Companies Made Millions During the Pandemic, Now Students are Fighting Back"; &
- Harwell, "A Face-Scanning Algorithm Increasingly Decides Whether You Deserve the Job"

W, 3/11: FQ6 due by 3 pm

Unit 5: Capitalism, Education, and Democracy

Week 9

M, 3/16: TP9 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 5, "Democracy" in *An Inquirer's Guide to Ethics in AI*, pp. 173-195;
- McCarthy-Jones, "The Autonomous Mind: The Right to Freedom of Thought in the Twenty-First Century";
- Farahany, "'Cognitive Liberty' Is the Human Right We Need to Talk About";
- Kinstler, "Big Tech Wants Direct Access to Our Brains";
- Scheiber, "How Uber Uses Psychological Tricks to Push Its Drivers' Buttons"; &
- O'Sullivan, et al, "You Can't Lose a Game if You Don't Play it"

W, 3/18: FQ7 due by 3 pm

Week 10

M, 3/23: TP10 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 5, "Democracy" in *An Inquirer's Guide to Ethics in AI*, pp. 195-210;
- Turkle, "Talk to Each Other, Not Your Phone";
- Turkle, "Who Do We Become When We Talk to Machines?";
- Jäger, "Automated Intimacy";
- Hill, "Tech Companies Have Created a Loneliness Doom Loop"; &
- Witt, "The Race to Build the World's Best Friend"

W, 3/25: FQ8 due by 3 pm

Unit 6: The Future

Week 11

M, 3/30: TP11 due by 3 pm

- Silk & MacDonald, chapter 6, "AI and Humanity" in *An Inquirer's Guide to Ethics in AI*;
- Diéguez & García-Barranquero, "The Singularity, Superintelligent Machines, and Mind Uploading: The Technological Future?"
- Benedikter, Giordano & Fitzgerald, "The Future of the Self Image of the Human Being in the Age of Transhumanism, Neurotechnology and Global Transition"; &
- Samuel, "Silicon Valley's Vision for AI? It's Religion Repackaged"

W, 4/1: FQ9 due by 3 pm

Week 12

M, 4/6: Easter Break, No Class

W, 4/8: TP12 due by 3 pm

- Thompson & Warzel, "Twelve Million Phones, One Data Set, Zero Privacy";
- Hill, "The Secretive Company That Might End Privacy as We Know It"
- Lanier & Weyl, "A Blueprint for a Better Digital Society"; &
- Video, "Jaron Lanier Fixes the Internet"
- Video, "I'm Building an Algorithm That Doesn't Rot Your Brain"

Week 13

M, 4/13: TP13 due by 3 pm

- Dewey, "Creative Democracy — The Task Before Us";
- Crawford, "Introduction," from *Atlas of AI*;
- Crawford, "Earth," from *Atlas of AI*; &
- Vallor, "Through the Looking Glass"

W, 4/15: FQ10 due by 3 pm

Unit 7: Group Presentations: Putting Computer Ethics to Work

Week 14

M, 4/20: Group Presentations

W, 4/22: No Class

Week 15

M, 4/27: Group Presentations

W, 4/29: Group Presentations

Week 16

M, 5/4: CATS & Final Conversation

Final Paper Due 4 pm, Saturday, May 9, 2026